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Saving Enlightenment: Jefferson’s Bible, Douglass’s Faith, and the Work of the Spirit

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This article argues that Frederick Douglass’s invocations of Christian spirituality, specifically his belief in divine power and prophecy, constitute a mode of political judgment that (1) grounds his moral convictions, (2) animates his immanent critique of proslavery theology and racial science from their own stated premises, and (3) widens the scope of public reason beyond secular rationalism, scientific empiricism, and inherited religious custom. Against Thomas Jefferson’s “materialist” foreclosure of spiritual discourse, which modern scholarship risks reproducing, Douglass envisions a liberal democratic order in which prophetic spirituality can refine and expand democratic commitments. Methodologically, this article models an approach to intellectual history that treats spirituality as a mode of political reasoning in its own right, rather than as background context or rhetorical convention. Recovering this dimension of Douglass’s thought complicates narratives of secularization and reconceives Enlightenment liberalism as a framework in which faith, reason, and democracy are fundamentally imbricated.

During his final decades on earth, Thomas Jefferson meticulously tailored the life of Jesus to fit the dimensions of his “materialist” vision of humanity. By 1820, the former president had recast the Gospels by removing every reference to miraculous healings and excising all claims affirming the deity of Christ. He sliced away pieces of New Testament stories until they depicted Jesus as a mere mortal whose moral words and actions never broached the boundaries of reason.¹ As the founder worked to expunge what he believed to be the fables and ravings of “spiritualism” and provide a system of Christian morality underwritten by empirical observations guided by objective reason, he translated the transcendent spirituality of the Christian Trinity into a terrestrial moral philosophy shaped by John Locke, Francis Bacon, and Isaac

¹ For a lively historical treatment of Jefferson’s redactions and the logical difficulties they posed see Peter Manseau, *The Jefferson Bible: A Biography* (Princeton, 2020). On Jefferson’s broader (and complicated) relationship to spirituality and religion see, for example, Thomas S. Kidd, *Thomas Jefferson: A Biography of Spirit and Flesh* (New Haven, 2022).

Newton.² In Jefferson's hands, supernatural frameworks were relegated to the realm of the unintelligible.

By purging the miraculous, Jefferson effectively foreclosed "spiritualism" as a viable theological position by rejecting (1) the validity of prophecy and other forms of revealed knowledge from scripture; (2) divine intervention, including miracles; and (3) the concrete power of an active and indwelling God. (I use "foreclosure" here in a psychoanalytic sense to indicate the exclusion of a proposition so complete that it can no longer be conceived or articulated as a source of knowledge or judgment.)³ In thus excluding "spiritualism"—what this article terms *the work of the spirit*, or Christian spirituality—Jefferson severed from within Enlightenment reason a central feature of early American and African American political thought: a mode of spiritual judgment grounded in moral conviction, political discernment, and prophetic critique.⁴ Accordingly, this article will distinguish among three domains that structure the analysis that follows: (1) *the work of the spirit*; (2) *religion*, understood as moral codes, customs, and traditions that do not necessarily imply the supernatural; and (3) *reason*, or modes of thinking derived from logic or empirical sources.⁵

Nineteenth-century black American thinkers, most notably Frederick Douglass, actively embraced Christian spirituality even as philosophical worldviews emerging from positivism began gaining prominence.⁶ The "wall" of separation that Jefferson proposed between church and state was meant to ensure that public reason could

²Thomas Jefferson, "To William Short, 13 April 1820," Jefferson, "To Benjamin Rush, 16 January 1811," in James P. McClure and J. Jefferson Looney, eds., *The Papers of Thomas Jefferson Digital Edition* (Charlottesville, 2008–20), at <https://rotunda.upress.virginia.edu/founders/TSJN-03-15-02-0505>.

³Political theorist Barnor Hesse helpfully reframes foreclosure as referencing "the discursive contexts in which particular terms or references become impossible to formulate because the means by which they could be formulated have been excluded from the discursive context." Hesse exemplifies the effects of this process in his close reading of Isaiah Berlin's two conceptions of liberty. See Barnor Hesse, "Escaping Liberty: Western Hegemony, Black Fugitivity," *Political Theory* 42 (2014), 288–313, at 298; Isaiah Berlin, "Two Concepts of Liberty," in Berlin, *Liberty: Incorporating Four Essays on Liberty*, ed. Henry Hardy (Oxford, 2002), 166–217, at 190–91. See also Judith Butler, *Excitable Speech: A Politics of the Performative* (New York, 1997), 139. For a different register of foreclosure tied to the erasure of black subjectivity, see Surya Parekh, *Black Enlightenment* (Durham, NC, 2023).

⁴I thank an anonymous peer reviewer for encouraging me, throughout this paper, to invoke a term other than what Jefferson calls "spiritualism," as the later nineteenth-century movement of spiritualism relates to a variety of mystical elements, including mediums, séances, and trance practices. I have thus chosen the term "work of the spirit" to refer to belief in divine agency, prophecy, and supernatural intervention as articulated within biblical Christianity.

⁵Remarkably, Jefferson believed that his reason-grounded materialism was a Christian framework, albeit one that denied miracles. He hoped Christianity could be fundamentally reformed into a religion rooted in his understanding of reason. On the nuances of his view see Johann N. Neem, "A Republican Reformation: Thomas Jefferson's Civil Religion and the Separation of Church from State," in Francis D. Cogliano, ed., *A Companion to Thomas Jefferson* (Malden, MA, 2012), 91–109. Regarding Jefferson's often contradictory religious, rational, and political commitments, Vincent Phillip Muñoz concludes, "Ironically, the American Founder who was perhaps the most dedicated to a politics based on reason alone appears to have left his position dependent on others' faith in its reasonableness." See Vincent Phillip Muñoz, *God and the Founders: Madison, Washington, and Jefferson* (New York, 2009), 115.

⁶While Jefferson's actions anticipate some positivist sensibilities, positivism as a philosophical school was formally codified in the mid-nineteenth century by French philosopher Auguste Comte. A positivist framework holds that assertions must be empirically provable through science to be considered valid and treats

flourish without what he regarded as “Platonic mysticisms.”⁷ Douglass, by contrast, suggested that moral insights and judgments shaped by the work of the spirit could promote equality, where rationalism alone proved insufficient to secure consistent recognition of human dignity. His writings refused to maintain rigid separations among spirituality, religion, and reason, creating a mode of prophetic political critique that Jefferson would have dismissed as irrational. However, Jefferson’s materialist reworking of scripture did not simply reflect his own private skepticism; it echoed a particular strand of Enlightenment thought that rendered spiritual discourse irrelevant—or even untenable—within the realm of public reason.⁸ It is precisely this movement that Douglass resisted, offering instead a mode of political engagement that fused faith with rational argument.

Douglass’s synthesis of spirituality, religion, and reason provided a durable form of moral authority in the face of oppression. Yet many modern scholars—intellectual historians and political theorists alike—have tended to discount his spirituality as rhetorical flourishes or inherited convention.⁹ Some translate his expressions of faith into theologically neutral philosophical terms, such as “morality” or “humanity.” Others, such as Matthew Stewart, go further, portraying Douglass as a thoroughgoing freethinker whose religious language merely masked skepticism or disregard for spirituality.¹⁰ These moves, however, risk repeating Jefferson’s gesture of foreclosure:

matters of faith as no longer authoritative. Auguste Comte, *Introduction to Positive Philosophy*, ed. Frederick Ferré (Indianapolis, 1988).

⁷For insightful analyses of Jefferson’s “wall” and desire to establish a civil religion guided by rational republican principles see Neem, “A Republican Reformation”; Muñoz, *God and the Founders*, 70–116.

⁸This is not to say that *all* Enlightenment thought dismissed spirituality. See, for example, William J. Bulman and Robert G. Ingram, eds., *God in the Enlightenment* (New York, 2016). Conversely, for a compelling argument regarding Enlightenment’s shifts towards secular, anthropocentric concerns see Margaret C. Jacob, *The Secular Enlightenment* (Princeton, 2019).

⁹On this point, see especially Lloyd, who urges that we should not dismiss Douglass’s appeals to the faith as “mere rhetoric,” but scholars must “work through this language rather than dismiss it.” Lloyd rightly argues that “Douglass’s invocations of God’s law are both rhetorical and substantive; indeed, the two interpretations cannot be detached from one another.” See Vincent Lloyd, “The Affect of God’s Law,” in Neil Roberts, ed., *A Political Companion to Frederick Douglass* (Lexington, 2018), 303–23, at 306, 308.

¹⁰While Matthew Stewart’s *An Emancipation of the Mind* exemplifies this approach most recently, other scholars have also made compelling claims for reading Douglass as a freethinker. See especially Christopher Cameron, *Black Freethinkers: A History of African American Secularism* (Evanston, 2019), 26–34; Zachary McLeod Hutchins, “Rejecting the Root: The Liberating, Anti-Christ Theology of Douglass’s Narrative,” *Nineteenth-Century Literature* 68 (2013), 292–322. Of note, Stewart charges historians, “with some notable exceptions,” of having “abetted” the public’s misguidedly optimistic view of religion vis-à-vis abolition by, among other things, downplaying its role in maintaining slavery in ways that were contrary to Douglass’s own freethinking beliefs. See also Stewart’s assessment of slaveholders’ diminishment of Enlightenment reason through appeals to religion and spirituality, which he contends operates under the following logic: “If human beings are equal in nature and reason, then their systematic subordination can only happen by appeal to something unreasonable and supernatural.” Matthew Stewart, *An Emancipation of the Mind: Radical Philosophy, the War over Slavery, and the Refounding of America* (New York, 2024), 9, 58. However, such stances tend to elide implicit (and explicit) assertions of the fundamental imbrication of reason and Christian spirituality expressed by Douglass and other abolitionists, which shaped their worldview. Moreover, arguments purportedly grounded in rational Enlightenment ideas have—apart from notions of spirituality—long been used to justify slavery and racial hierarchy, as in the case of Thomas Jefferson. On this

excising the extant spiritual language of Douglass's writings and speeches and treating his expressions of faith strictly in materialist, instrumental, or strategic terms.¹¹

This article contends that Douglass's early invocations of the work of the spirit constitute an indispensable dimension of his political outlook and ought to figure centrally in intellectual histories and theoretical reconstructions of his ideas. Against the materialist Enlightenment currents exemplified by figures such as Jefferson, Douglass developed a spiritually inflected conception of public reason—one that bridged faith, empiricism, and politics—to contest both proslavery appeals to religion and the pernicious claims of racial science.¹² Recovering this dimension of Douglass's thought, most evident in his early work, yields three central functions of Christian spirituality in his political theory: (1) it grounds his normative political judgments, (2) it animates his religious and scientific critiques of slavery and its defenders, and (3) it expands, rather than circumscribes, the domain of public reason.

Methodologically, this article models an approach to intellectual history that moves beyond familiar frameworks that either treat religion as a background influence on political action or reduce religious appeals to rhetorical convention. Both approaches diminish the transformative role of the work of the spirit. By contrast, I argue that Douglass treated Christian spirituality as a mode of political reasoning in its own right, such that spiritual conviction and political judgment function as an integrated mode of thought. To be sure, Jefferson's epistemic categories—his redaction of miracles, his materialist approach to reason, and his foreclosure of divine agency—have structured influential accounts within nineteenth-century intellectual historiography. Yet Douglass's thought cannot be contained within this Jeffersonian frame: he destabilizes it in ways that expose the limits of the founder's narrowed materialist epistemology. Accordingly, I compare these two thinkers across generations to show how Jefferson's epistemic categories endured—and were contested—within nineteenth-century debates about religion, public reason, and democracy.

As I have argued elsewhere, and as scholars such as Hannah Spahn and Surya Parekh have recently developed in distinct but complementary ways, Enlightenment

point see Keidrick Roy, *American Dark Age: Racial Feudalism and the Rise of Black Liberalism* (Princeton, 2024), 42–66.

¹¹There are, of course, works that prominently feature rigorous examinations of the substance and impact of Douglass's faith. See, for example, David W. Blight, *Frederick Douglass' Civil War: Keeping Faith in Jubilee* (Baton Rouge, 1989); Scott C. Williamson, *The Narrative Life: The Moral and Religious Thought of Frederick Douglass* (Macon, 2003); Reginald F. Davis, *Frederick Douglass: A Precursor to Liberation Theology* (Macon, 2005); George Shulman, *American Prophecy: Race and Redemption in American Political Culture* (Minneapolis, 2008), 16–20; John Ernest, "Crisis and Faith in Douglass's Work," in Maurice S. Lee, ed., *The Cambridge Companion to Frederick Douglass* (Cambridge, 2009), 60–72; Vincent Lloyd, *Black Natural Law* (Oxford, 2016), 1–31; Lloyd, "The Affect of God's Law"; David Howard-Pitney, *African American Jeremiad: Appeals for Justice in America* (Philadelphia, 2005), 15–52; D. H. Dilbeck, *Frederick Douglass: America's Prophet* (Chapel Hill, 2018). Even so, Douglass's faith convictions often receive scant or passing mention in political theory and intellectual-historical analyses of his work and its impact.

¹²For political philosopher John Rawls, "public reason" applies "to citizens when they engage in political advocacy in the public forum" and "public and government officers in official forums" such as "debates and votes on the floor of the legislature." See John Rawls, *Political Liberalism* (New York, 2005), 252, 253.

ideas should not be separated from black British and American intellectual history.¹³ Early black thinkers did not merely inherit Enlightenment categories; when read on their own terms, figures from poet Phillis Wheatley to abolitionist Frederick Douglass exposed and reworked the movement's internal tensions, including judgments about the nature of reason itself. Spahn's treatment of Jefferson and Wheatley is suggestive in this regard. She argues that Jefferson's avowed empiricism nonetheless rests on commitments shaped by local sentiments, entrenched prejudices, and subjective feeling, while African American figures such as Wheatley, David Walker, and Douglass—long dismissed as deficient in reason—more consistently articulated a principled worldview capable of exposing the circumscribed universalism embedded in Jeffersonian thought.¹⁴ Against this backdrop, I argue that Douglass's synthesis of spirituality, religion, and rationality is not external to Enlightenment reason but instead clarifies its moral stakes and expands its critical reach. Where Spahn emphasizes the role of subjective feeling in a primarily secular rationalist context, and Parekh examines providence as a formative element of black subjectivity rather than a form of political thought in its own right, I foreground Douglass's Christian spirituality as a constitutive dimension of political reasoning itself.¹⁵

In what follows, I will survey Douglass's writings and speeches between 1845 and 1865 as deliberate *coarticulations* of spirituality, religion, and rationality, showing how he alternates among spiritually informed indictment, religious reformist critique, and rational argumentation to animate the aforementioned functions. I develop this frame through brief treatments of his (1) 1845 and 1855 autobiographies, which underscore his sense of spirituality as justification for antislavery arguments; (2) pre-Civil War speeches, which exemplify a spiritually grounded immanent critique of "Christian" proslavery theology and racial science by pressing these doctrines on their own stated premises; and (3) wartime speeches, especially "Mission of the War" (1864), where the apocalyptic register of his religious spirituality works to confirm and amplify, rather than oppose, nineteenth-century public reason under conditions of national crisis.¹⁶ Along the way, I offer an extended close reading of Douglass's 1854 *The Claims of the Negro Ethnologically Considered* address, which I take to be the cornerstone of his synthetic approach to reconstructing public reason in a liberal democracy, whereby the work of the spirit exposes reason's blind spots and challenges the abuses of instrumentalized religion. Although modern receptions of Douglass's writings and speeches often echo Jefferson's foreclosure of spiritual elements, these cases demonstrate how

¹³Keidrick Roy, "Jefferson's Map, Douglass's Territory: The Black Reconstruction of Enlightenment in America" (doctoral dissertation, Harvard University, 2022); Roy, *American Dark Age*; Keidrick Roy, *The Underground Enlightenment: A Story of the Black Reconstruction of American Thought* (Princeton, forthcoming); Parekh, *Black Enlightenment*; Hannah Spahn, *Black Reason, White Feeling: The Jeffersonian Enlightenment in the African American Tradition* (Charlottesville, 2024).

¹⁴For an alternative account of Jefferson's circumscribed universalism that emphasizes his commitment to maintaining a "natural" aristocracy that nonetheless presupposed an intransigent racial hierarchy see Roy, *American Dark Age*, 42–66.

¹⁵Spahn, *Black Reason, White Feeling*; Parekh, *Black Enlightenment*, 137.

¹⁶For rich evaluations of Douglass's foundational spiritual commitments as expressed in his autobiographies and speeches, which I cannot fully treat here, see Blight, *Frederick Douglass' Civil War*; Davis, *Frederick Douglass: A Precursor to Liberation Theology*; Dilbeck, *Frederick Douglass: America's Prophet*.

Douglass envisioned and modeled a framework for public reason open to prophetic revision.

Not just morality

To understand why Douglass's affirmations of faith matter for intellectual history and the history of political thought, this section examines interpretations of his religious commitments in recent scholarship. In so doing, it joins historian Benjamin E. Park and others in challenging secularizing tendencies that continue to shape intellectual historiography.¹⁷ As Park has argued, even David Blight's exemplary 2018 biography *Frederick Douglass: Prophet of Freedom* tends to downplay the "instigative power" of Douglass's Christianity, which profoundly shaped the abolitionist's worldview.¹⁸ By contrast, Blight's study from nearly three decades earlier, *Frederick Douglass' Civil War: Keeping Faith in Jubilee* (1989), treats Douglass's millennial Christianity as a serious intellectual force, as will be shown below, while the significance of Douglass's spiritual vocabulary in *Prophet of Freedom*, written for a popular audience, is notably muted. While this shift in emphasis leaves a sense of Douglass's spirituality intact (indeed, Blight does not deny its importance), it nonetheless indexes a contemporary disciplinary tendency to translate the spiritual dimensions of his prophetic conviction into moral and political idioms legible within the dominant frame of secular public reason.

Where Park's analysis of Douglass as "a prophet in the more archaic form: speaking with and for God" leads him to ask what it might mean to "make Douglass a framing figure for nineteenth-century Christianity" and trace his influence on American religious thought, I instead examine how Douglass's spirituality informs his political imagination, specifically his understanding of a liberal democratic framework for public reason that makes space for both reason and the work of the spirit.¹⁹ In this respect, my approach also departs from secularist interpretations of Douglass by arguing that

¹⁷See Benjamin E. Park, "Frederick Douglass: Prophet of Freedom, by David W. Blight and Frederick Douglass: America's Prophet, by D. H. Dilbeck" (review essay), *Journal of the American Academy of Religion* 87 (2019), 1209–19, at 1217. Park's essay intersects with broader debates in secularism studies. Scholars such as Craig Calhoun, Charles Taylor, Joan Scott, and Cornel West have shown the limits of some strands of secularist arguments that seek to isolate public reason by excluding religious or prophetic language. See Craig Calhoun, Mark Juergensmeyer, and Jonathan VanAntwerpen, eds., *Rethinking Secularism* (Oxford, 2011); Charles Taylor, *A Secular Age* (Cambridge, MA, 2009); Joan Wallach Scott, *Sex and Secularism* (Princeton, 2018); Cornel West, "Prophetic Religion and the Future of Capitalist Civilization," in Eduardo Mendieta and Jonathan VanAntwerpen, eds., *The Power of Religion in the Public Sphere* (New York, 2011), 92–100.

¹⁸Park shows how Blight's reading of Douglass largely emphasizes biblical language as a vehicle for expressions of Douglass's beliefs rather than Douglass's beliefs being shaped and formed by his Christian commitments. See David W. Blight, *Frederick Douglass: Prophet of Freedom* (New York, 2018); Park, "Frederick Douglass: Prophet of Freedom, by David W. Blight and Frederick Douglass: America's Prophet, by D. H. Dilbeck," 1211.

¹⁹Park, "Frederick Douglass: Prophet of Freedom, by David W. Blight and Frederick Douglass: America's Prophet, by D. H. Dilbeck," 1214, 1217. Still, on the theological limitations of Douglass's sense of spirituality in the field of religious studies see J. Kameron Carter, "Race, Religion, and the Contradictions of Identity: A Theological Engagement with Douglass's 1845 Narrative," *Modern Theology* 21 (2005), 37–65.

his spirituality constituted a mode of political theorizing that insists on democracy's openness to transcendent claims.

For Douglass, such a liberal democratic framework should be guided by a balance between universal principles of toleration and prophetic affirmations of human dignity, explicitly informed by Christian spirituality.²⁰ In a just liberal polity, participants must respect the rule of law—understood as a set of propositions accessible to all through reason—while remaining open to challenge and correction through prophetic spiritual judgment, especially where injustice is sustained under the apparent authority of religion, reason, and science. In this sense, Douglass's invocations of spirituality aimed to cultivate a third space irreducible to scientific knowledge, secular rationalism, and inherited religious custom; each of which, from different directions, had been appropriated by enslavers and their supporters to maintain racial oppression. His implicit revision of Jefferson's "wall," then, departed from the founder's effort to foreclose Christian spirituality. By contrast, Douglass envisioned a political order composed of individuals sensitive to the work of the spirit and prophetic critique.²¹

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Under the influence of the prominent abolitionist William Lloyd Garrison during the 1840s, Douglass held that the United States' political institutions were so thoroughly entangled with slavery that formal participation in politics, including voting, would be morally illegitimate and thus ineffectual. Against this backdrop, he called for resisting all forms of direct political participation in a government established under the "radically and essentially slave-holding" US Constitution.²² Accordingly, Douglass claimed in 1847 that one ought not "have part nor lot" with the American government, declaring, "I had rather that my right hand should wither by my side than cast a ballot under the Constitution of the United States."²³ However, by the early

²⁰On Douglass's liberal positions on religious toleration see especially Nicholas Buccola, *The Political Thought of Frederick Douglass: In Pursuit of American Liberty* (New York, 2013), 56–60. On Douglass establishing an effective balance between notions of faith and reason see Nick Bromell, *The Time Is Always Now: Black Thought and the Transformation of US Democracy* (New York, 2013), 102–12; Peter C. Myers, *Frederick Douglass: Race and the Rebirth of American Liberalism* (Lawrence, 2008), 49.

²¹George Shulman has demonstrated how prophecy provides a basis for projecting a type of "democratic authority" that can render ethical verdicts from a distinctive moral-theological standpoint, thereby resisting the capriciousness of relativism. Shulman concedes that expressions of "authority" are usually associated with "dogmatism and depicted as antithetical to democratic life." However, he suggests that "even as we continually suspect and unmask authority as a form of power, we still praise good teachers, struggle to be good parents, grapple with internalized authority to distinguish our 'own' voice, persuade others to our views. And authority remains inescapably central to a *democratic* life, as we make and revise judgments of others and their conduct, weigh the authority of different claims and the claims of different authorities, make commitments, and authorize actions." See George Shulman, "Thinking Authority Democratically: Prophetic Practices, White Supremacy, and Democratic Politics," *Political Theory* 36 (2008), 727, 708–34, at 708–9, 728, original emphasis. I should add that while slavery was often justified by recourse to religiously oriented language, it was also denounced as morally reprehensible on religious terms, as will be seen below in the writings of Frederick Douglass.

²²Frederick Douglass, "American Slavery, Speech Delivered at Market Hall, New York City, October 22, 1847," in *The Life and Writings of Frederick Douglass*, vol. 1, *Early Years*, ed. Philip S. Foner (New York, 1950), 269–78, at 274.

1850s, Douglass had reversed his position. He came to celebrate the Constitution as a “glorious liberty document,” claiming that it contains no “single proslavery clause” but instead articulates “principles and purposes entirely hostile to the existence of slavery.”²⁴

Despite this seismic shift in Douglass’s thinking—from rejecting the legitimacy of the American constitutional project to embracing the possibilities articulated in its founding documents—he nonetheless maintained his commitment to what political theorist Nick Bromell describes as a “tense and dynamic equilibrium” between God’s eternal law, which transcends history, and the exercise of human agency within it.²⁵ Christian spirituality thus remained foundational to Douglass’s personal philosophy even as his political conclusions changed.²⁶ From the outset of his public career, he articulated his faith as a source of moral judgment forged through his theological commitments and lived experience under racial domination. As historian D. H. Dilbeck has persuasively argued, it was precisely this spiritual orientation that enabled Douglass’s decisive turn toward an antislavery interpretation of the Constitution.²⁷

Although some scholars have interpreted Douglass’s critiques of the entanglement of religion and slavery in the antebellum era as suggestive of an attachment to skepticism, secular humanism, or even atheism, his early writings instead point to intentional

²³Ibid., 275.

²⁴Frederick Douglass, “What to the Slave Is the Fourth of July?”, in *The Speeches of Frederick Douglass: A Critical Edition*, ed. John R. McKivigan, Julie Husband, and Heather L. Kaufman (New Haven, 2018), 55–92, at 88, 89–90. On the historical, philosophical, and legal resonance of Douglass’s transformation see, for example, Manisha Sinha, *The Slave’s Cause: A History of Abolition* (New Haven, 2016), 491–495; Myisha Cherry, “The Kant and Race Debate: A Frederick Douglass Intervention,” *Southern Journal of Philosophy* 61 (2023), 51–62; Bradley Rebeiro, “Frederick Douglass and the Original Originalists,” *BYU Law Review* 48 (2023), 909–76; Ian Zuckerman, “The Abolitionist State of Exception: Frederick Douglass’s Constitutionalism,” *American Political Thought* 14 (2025), 78–110; Philip Yaure, *Seizing Citizenship: Frederick Douglass’s Abolitionist Republicanism* (New York, 2025); Dennis C. Rasmussen, *Frederick Douglass’s American Founding: How the Nation’s Fiercest Critic Embraced the Constitution* (Princeton, 2026).

²⁵Bromell, *Time Is Always Now*, 111, 107–10. My work is aligned with Bromell’s reading of Douglass as a figure who neither makes the distinction between “God’s eternal principles and higher laws that stand outside history” and “the muck and mire” of existence” in a (materialist) historical context nor distinguishes between “faith in the eternal laws of God and faith in the political agency of men and women.” Ibid., 110.

²⁶Bolstering his claim that Douglass was “a creative, critical theist trying to find a place in a world full of evil” during the 1850s, Jared Hickman points to scholars such as John Ernest, who positions Douglass as a “man of lasting faith and a religious leader” who kept up “a faith in a Christianity that could be realized and maintained only by way of resistance to the violated religion that surrounded him.” See Jared Hickman, “Douglass Unbound,” *Nineteenth-Century Literature* 68 (2013), 323–62, at 330, 330 n. 16; Ernest, “Crisis and Faith in Douglass’s Work,” 62. On Douglass’s early and long-standing commitment to religious faith see also Blight, *Frederick Douglass’s Civil War*, 7–8; Williamson, *The Narrative Life*; Davis, *Precursor to Liberation Theology*; Lloyd, “The Affect of God’s Law.” For critiques of Blight, Ernest, and Davis for leaving out Douglass’s 1845 *Narrative* in their affirmation of Douglass’s commitment to Christianity during his early years see Hutchins, “Rejecting the Root.”

²⁷Dilbeck, *Frederick Douglass: America’s Prophet*, 75–89.

meldings of rational critique and Christian convictions.²⁸ Just two years after the publication of his widely acclaimed 1845 *Narrative*, Douglass made his commitments explicit:

I dwell mostly upon the religious aspect [of slavery] because I believe it is the religious people who are to be relied on in this Anti-Slavery movement. Do not misunderstand my railing—do not class me with those who despise religion—do not identify me with the infidel. I love the religion of Christianity—which cometh from above—which is pure, peaceable, gentle, easy to be entreated, full of good fruits, and without hypocrisy ... [However,] I despise that religion ... which can talk about human rights yonder and traffic in human flesh here.²⁹

Rather than rejecting Christianity, Douglass affirms its liberatory potential when rightly interpreted. This position structured his early political reasoning and animated his prophetic critique of injustice.

Moreover, despite the horrors of slavery and the prejudices condoned by ostensibly religious arguments, Douglass consistently maintained that the fundamental principles of the Bible were productive and liberatory, much as he argued that the Constitution, when rightly interpreted, embodied principles hostile to slavery. Responding to the Supreme Court's 1857 *Dred Scott* decision, which declared that African Americans were not citizens and possessed "no rights which the white man was bound to respect," Douglass rejected the conclusion that either the Bible or the Constitution should be abandoned because of corrupt interpreters. He contended that there

is no evidence that the Bible is a bad book because those who profess to believe the Bible are bad. The slaveholders of the South, and many of their wicked allies at the North, claim the Bible for slavery; shall we, therefore, fling the Bible away as a pro-slavery book? It would be as reasonable to do so as it would be to fling away the Constitution.³⁰

²⁸While Nick Bromell and Scott C. Williamson have plausibly suggested that Douglass grew less committed to Christianity over the course of his life, Christopher Cameron contends that Douglass expressed "atheist themes" in his first autobiography, citing Zachary McLeod Hutchins, who also questions Douglass's commitments to the Christian religion in his parallel reading of Douglass's 1845 *Narrative*. Hutchins describes the text as highlighting the "antagonistic nature" of Douglass's "relationship with Christianity." Moreover, for Hutchins, Douglass's *Narrative* "destabilizes the Bible and rejects Christianity proper." See Nick Bromell, *The Powers of Dignity: The Black Political Philosophy of Frederick Douglass* (Durham, NC, 2021), 204; Williamson, *The Narrative Life*; Cameron, *Black Freethinkers*, 26–8, 30–34; Hutchins, "Rejecting the Root," 296. However, my examination of Douglass's early writings and speeches more broadly reveals him as, on balance, ridiculing the foundations of "pro-slavery religion" without repudiating Christian spirituality or what I have been calling the work of the spirit. On the possible influence of West African religious culture and African spirituality on Douglass's narrative see Alphonso F. Saville, "I Know It Was the Blood: Prophetic Initiation and Retributive Justice in the Narratives of John Marrant, Nat Turner, and Frederick Douglass," *Journal of Africana Religions* 7 (2019), 234–54.

²⁹Douglass, "American Slavery," 273.

³⁰Frederick Douglass, "The Dred Scott Decision," in *The Portable Frederick Douglass*, ed. John Stauffer and Henry Louis Gates Jr (New York, 2016), 248–68, at 267.

Here Douglass does not retreat from religious authority but pointedly distinguishes between the Bible as a source of moral and spiritual truth and the distorted religious frameworks that sanctified racial domination. Read alongside his constitutional arguments, this passage shows that Douglass valued both texts as legitimate objects of interpretation within public reason. The question that follows, then, is not whether Douglass appealed to scripture, but how he evaluated its authority. Was it merely a source of moral guidance, or a wellspring of spiritual power and political judgment?

The source of normative judgement: the work of the spirit in Douglass's early autobiographies

Douglass's first two autobiographies, published in 1845 and 1855, frame their author's spirituality as a source of political judgment. In this way, they invert Jefferson's effort to excise the miraculous from practical and political reasoning by affirming the work of the spirit—belief in divine power and prophecy—as a warrant for both moral accountability and political equality. For contemporary readers, Douglass's spirituality may seem antiquated, uncompromising, or even antithetical to pluralistic values. As political theorist George Shulman has argued, “prophecy” is often at odds with the liberal aims of plurality because of its unyielding attachment to a particular form of moral judgment rooted in an ostensibly exclusionary worldview. He contends that prophecy's

political value is inseparable from what we find dangerous about it: the exercise of authority in claims about willful blindness and judgment of injustice, in uncompromising and aggressive calls to conflict over fateful and costly choices, in intense avowals of solidarity, in urgent demands for accountability on behalf of reimagined community, and in poetic promises of redemption—not to mention intensities and cadences of speech that raise the temperature in the body politic.³¹

This affirmation provides a useful frame for approaching Douglass's autobiographical writings, which do not abandon prophecy's moral force but reconfigure it in ways that challenge the presumed opposition between prophetic judgment and liberal democratic reason.

For these reasons, it is essential not to translate prophetic voices prematurely into idioms only amenable to Jeffersonian materialism or liberal rationalism. Such translations can diminish forms of critique that confront audiences with moral truths that may not be fully articulable by instrumental reason alone. Douglass's campaign to end slavery and eliminate racial prejudice depended on his sustained challenge to the social, political, *and* spiritual violations that structured these institutions. By explicitly advancing faith-based claims while holding them in tension with reason and the demands of prudential judgment within a liberal democratic framework, Douglass articulated a form of abolitionist argumentation whose force is best grasped in its original terms. To elide his spiritual language is to diminish the moral authority of

³¹Shulman, *American Prophecy*, xv.

those claims and to misrepresent the dialectical structure of his reasoning, which consistently joined faith and reason as mutually reinforcing sources of critique. In this way, Douglass unsettled Jefferson's "wall" of separation not by rejecting reason, but by treating spirituality as a coequal source of political judgment.

After all, Douglass did more than rhetorically gesture to the work of the spirit. Across his writings and speeches, he exhibited a sustained pattern of conviction suggesting that the spirituality he articulated was constitutive of his political imagination rather than merely ornamental. As David Blight emphasizes in his earlier biography, Douglass's "millennial [Christian] symbolism was not merely a rhetorical device"; it was "a real source of faith, not simply a benign spiritual exercise." He further contends that "[t]he deepest source of Douglass' hopes lay where all great dreams are preserved: in the spiritual and moral imagination." By the 1840s, Blight notes, the power derived from the spiritual authority on which Douglass stood "had shaped his thinking and provided perhaps the deepest layer of his prewar hope."³² When modern readers translate Douglass's own claims and emphasis on spiritual power into materialist idioms stripped of their theological underpinnings, they risk losing not just Douglass's rhetorical force but the very source of authority and motivation that animated his abolitionist vision.

Blight characterizes Douglass's millennial Christian view as one informed by "eschatological symbolism, [belief in] God's second coming and retributive justice, and the American sense of mission as a 'redeemer nation.'"³³ As a widely shared perspective during Douglass's time, millennialism, which held that "human will and divine power were equal forces," was rooted in the idea that "an apocalyptic God ... could enter history and force nations, like individuals, to chart a new course." Against arguments advanced by David Martin and others that Douglass strayed from his foundational religious commitments, Blight insists that Douglass "did not abandon a 'sacred world view' [to] develop a 'supremely rational view'" later in life. Instead, he continued to develop a millennial framework, even as his political influence expanded, integrating spiritual authority with prophetic conceptions of historical intervention as a basis for moral and political judgment.³⁴

As Douglass's star continued to rise early in his career, he increasingly invoked the work of the spirit in ways that directly unsettled materialist accounts of political judgment. His antebellum autobiographies foregrounded spirituality as constitutive of his social and political outlook, even as he relentlessly condemned the distortions of "religion" by slaveholders, who, in his view, adulterated the truth and beauty of Christ's message.³⁵ In fact, Douglass added an Appendix to his 1845 *Narrative* to anticipate

³²Blight, *Frederick Douglass' Civil War*, 9.

³³*Ibid.*, 8.

³⁴*Ibid.*, 10 n. 15; Waldo E. Martin, *The Mind of Frederick Douglass* (Chapel Hill, 1984), 173–82; see also Ernest, "Crisis and Faith in Douglass's Work." For a different take on Douglass's religious commitments later in life see Nick Bromell's analysis of Douglass's gradual shift "from a Christianity-based philosophy to a more human-centered one" that focused on "soul" toward the end of his career. Bromell, *Powers of Dignity*, 204–5.

³⁵For other ways in which Douglass says the influence of religion contributed to the "shaping and directing of [his] mind" see Frederick Douglass, *My Bondage and My Freedom* (New York, 1855), 165–9, esp. 168.

and preempt readers who might misinterpret his critique and label him an “opponent of all religion.” He insists that when he criticizes “religion,” he exclusively means “the *slaveholding religion* of this land, and with no possible reference to Christianity proper.” Douglass sharpens this distinction by asserting that “between the Christianity of this land, and the Christianity of Christ, I recognize the widest possible difference—so wide, that to receive the one as good, pure, and holy, is of necessity to reject the other as bad, corrupt, and wicked.”³⁶ Against the corrupted religion of enslavers, Douglass presents his abolitionist cause as fundamentally “sacred,” thereby situating it within the moral and spiritual authority of the Bible rightly interpreted.³⁷ He closes the Appendix by punctuating this claim in explicitly eschatological terms, calling upon divine judgment to confront a nation he regarded as both spiritually impious and politically illiberal. Citing a verse repeated in Jeremiah 5:9, 5:29, and 9:9, Douglass writes, “Shall I not visit for these things? saith the Lord. Shall not my soul be avenged on such a nation as this?”³⁸

In his 1855 autobiography, *My Bondage and My Freedom*, Douglass likewise treats his spiritual commitments as an epistemic warrant, one that authorizes not only moral accountability but also political equality. Here, the language of providence underwrites his antislavery claims by grounding them in a prophetic vision of universal human dignity compatible with a just and liberal social order. Reflecting on his early life, Douglass recalls that before the age of thirteen and “previous to my contemplation of the anti-slavery movement and its probable results, my mind had been seriously awakened to the subject of religion.” For him, “religion” involved “change of heart which comes by ‘casting all one’s care’ upon God, and by having faith in Jesus Christ, as the Redeemer, Friend, and Savior of those who diligently seek Him.” After seeing the “world in a new light” following his faithful embrace of Jesus, he recognized that he “loved all mankind—slaveholders not excepted; though I abhorred slavery more than ever.”³⁹ Douglass’s phrasing here is powerful. Christian spirituality does not merely moderate his opposition to injustice but intensifies it, even as it enables him to express love for the very people who distorted his religion and assailed his liberty.

In articulating these sentiments, including his desire to “have the world converted” and to gain “a thorough acquaintance with the contents of the Bible,” Douglass explicitly affirmed his commitment to Christian spirituality and his belief in the immanent and indwelling power of God to act within history, rather than exclusively beyond it. For him, though Nat Turner’s “insurrection” was unsuccessful, the “alarm and terror” of its reverberations amplified the sentiment that “God was angry with the white people because of their slaveholding wickedness, and, therefore, his judgments were abroad [meaning widespread] in the land.” Tellingly, he concludes that it was “impossible for me not to hope much from the abolition movement when I saw it supported by the Almighty and armed with DEATH!”⁴⁰ Read in context, this passage reveals that

³⁶Frederick Douglass, *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, an American Slave* (Boston, 1845), 118–19, original emphasis.

³⁷Douglass, *Narrative*, 125.

³⁸*Ibid.*, 122–3.

³⁹Douglass, *My Bondage*, 166–7.

⁴⁰*Ibid.*, 165–6.

Douglass had been thinking on two simultaneous temporal registers: the earthly realm of political and moral reform and the eschatological realm of divine judgment. He thus envisioned the abolition of slavery as a political imperative underwritten by spiritual accountability.

Douglass made similar claims about the capacity for God's active spiritual intervention to transform material and political conditions through his relationship with a "good old colored man" named Uncle Lawson, whom he described as his "spiritual father" and with whom he "often" prayed and spent much of his Sunday leisure time. Reflecting on Lawson's influence some two decades later, Douglass recalled that the prophecies his mentor shared "threw my thoughts into a channel from which they have never entirely diverged." Perhaps inspired by the work of the spirit, Lawson assured Douglass that he would not be "a slave FOR LIFE" but that God could divinely intervene in his material conditions of servitude. "The Lord can make you free, my dear," Lawson told him. "All things are possible with him ... 'if you want liberty' ... 'ask the Lord for it, in faith, AND HE WILL GIVE IT TO YOU.'" Douglass confirms his acceptance of this belief in an active spiritual power capable of shaping the material and political world when he writes, "Thus assured, and cheered on, under the inspiration of hope, I worked and prayed with a light heart, believing that my life was under the guidance of a wisdom higher than my own."⁴¹

All told, to read Douglass's antebellum narratives—especially his critiques of "religion," which he clarifies as "*slaveholding religion*"—without attending to his spiritual register is to understate the theological grounding of his political claims and to obscure the basis of normative judgment that informs his later political thought.

Empowering immanent critique: the work of the spirit in Douglass's 1850s speeches

In the decade leading up to the Civil War, Douglass increasingly mobilized his spiritual convictions as a mechanism of immanent critique to expose the contradictions of proslavery ministers and demonstrate how prophetic language could productively reform religion from within its own terms.⁴² Building on this formative spiritual worldview, Douglass's speeches frequently alternated between prophetic indictment and political argument, thereby transforming spiritual condemnation into a strategy of public reason that revealed "Christian" proslavery religion not only as theologically bankrupt but also as fundamentally illiberal and antidemocratic.

In addition to grounding his belief in an active and indwelling God capable of intervening in history to destroy slavery, Douglass's spiritual commitments also informed his critique of the moral and rhetorical contradictions embedded in proslavery logic. He argued, for example, that slaveholders, whom many Americans mistakenly regarded as "respectable," must instead be exposed as the "disrespectable" moral core

⁴¹Ibid., 167–9.

⁴²For non-religious uses of immanent critique in the writings of Douglass and other black American thinkers see Keidrick Roy, *American Dark Age: Racial Feudalism and the Rise of Black Liberalism* (Princeton, 2024), 147, 163–4, 166–8.

of the peculiar institution. Douglass observed that “one of the most direct” and “powerful means of making” an enslaver a “respectable man is to say that he is a Christian,” a designation that commanded widespread “affection and regard” in America.⁴³

By invoking the designation “Christian”—a believer in the Jesus of the Bible whose full power and scope of being Jefferson’s *Bible* circumscribed—Douglass activated both the religion’s moral commitments and its concomitant metaphysical claims. These dimensions cannot be separated, since “Christian” indexes not merely a social identity but adherence to a tradition that affirms divine judgment, moral accountability, and the reality of supernatural power. Unlike deists or atheists, Christians openly profess the divine character of Jesus as disclosed through biblical miracles, most centrally the resurrection. Had Douglass instead condemned slaveholders simply as immoral or inhumane, his critique would have remained external to the spiritual tradition he engaged. By insisting instead that they were not the *Christians* they claimed to be, he invoked an immanent spiritual critique, exposing proslavery religion as theologically bankrupt on its own terms.⁴⁴

Douglass also deployed spiritually inflected immanent critique to challenge so-called Christian “ministers” who, in the wake of the 1850 Fugitive Slave Law, used their pulpits to enjoin obedience to its dictates. Such sermons threatened to jeopardize the freedom of all African Americans, regardless of status, by making them vulnerable to capture in the North.⁴⁵ In an 1851 antislavery lecture, Douglass records one such minister, John Chase Lord of Buffalo, New York, who contended that abolitionists cannot successfully overturn the “existence of domestic slavery,” since it was “expressly allowed, sanctioned and regulated by the Supreme Law-giver, in the divine economy which he gave to the Hebrew State.”⁴⁶ Douglass cites another clergyman, Leonard Elijah Lathrop, as similarly believing that “the duty of the Christian and the citizen” is “that both patriotism and religion require that the law should be obeyed.”⁴⁷

Strikingly, such arguments, in effect, exemplified the very abuse of religious authority that Jefferson had warned against: the invocation of divine sanction to legitimate domination. Douglass would agree, but not by rejecting Christianity as such. Instead, he condemned these ministers for having “blasphemously paraded” everything held “sacred in heaven and earth—God, Christ and the Apostles, the Bible, Christianity and patriotism” in the service of injustice.⁴⁸ In doing so, Douglass subjected proslavery theology to an immanent critique, exposing it as incompatible with both Christianity

⁴³Frederick Douglass, “The Free Church and Slavery, speech at Glasgow, Scotland, May 29, 1846,” in *The Life and Writings of Frederick Douglass*, 1: 178.

⁴⁴Matthew Stewart catalogues such proslavery theological arguments vis-à-vis abolitionist positions in *An Emancipation of the Mind*, 79–92. Even so, Stewart generally finds abolitionist arguments to be insufficient and reads the Bible as silent on slavery at best and, at worst, complicit in justifying it. However, Douglass’s style of immanent critique, which draws on biblical sources, advances a sharp corrective to proslavery religion.

⁴⁵For a classic first-person account detailing the capture and enslavement of a free black man following the passage of the Fugitive Slave Law see Solomon Northup, *Twelve Years a Slave* (Auburn, 1853).

⁴⁶Frederick Douglass, “American Slavery Lecture No. VII, January 12, 1851,” in *The Life and Writings of Frederick Douglass*, vol. 5, *Supplementary Volume*, ed. Philip S. Foner (New York, 1975), 170–80, at 172.

⁴⁷*Ibid.*, 173.

⁴⁸*Ibid.*, 173–4.

(properly understood) and the moral commitments of a democratic framework of public reason.

Amplifying his criticism of religious appeals used to sustain slavery, Douglass contended that the “responsibility of politicians for slavery is great; but *infinitely greater* is the guilt of the American clergy” because of the extraordinary authority religious rhetoric conferred upon the institution. He thus identified something distinctive about the power of spiritual premises, especially in the hands of unscrupulous proslavery ministers. Douglass adds that religious leaders “frame a tangled web of arguments in support of slavery, of which politicians would never dream, and urge them with a show of piety which, in any other men, would but provoke popular contempt and scorn. Common men would be utterly ashamed to shield villainy under such sophistry.”⁴⁹

Pushing back against those who would contend that his language was too “harsh,” Douglass asks

what language is sufficiently stern and denunciatory to characterize the conduct of men who, while acting as the constituted guardians of the public morality, and claiming the reverence and respect due to those who hold their commission from the most high God, yet bring the whole scope of their influence to the side of the oppressor against the oppressed, to prop up a system in which are combined every sin and pollution that has a name.⁵⁰

Taken together, Douglass does not merely denounce proslavery perspectives on moral grounds within public reason. He also draws on his deeply considered spiritual commitments to intensify his refutation of purportedly Christian proslavery premises. Eliding Douglass’s spirituality thus tends to blunt the theological basis of his rhetorical power. All told, Douglass not only meets proslavery religious leaders on their own terms but also demonstrates the value of deploying spiritual premises as a form of public reason to address purportedly religious arguments that violate the moral and metaphysical commitments of their own belief system.⁵¹ These insights reveal the distinctive force of Douglass’s interrogation of the proclaimed Christianity of enslavers in the decade preceding the Civil War. Treating Douglass’s criticisms as mere rhetoric flattens the richly layered architecture of his immanent critique.

⁴⁹Ibid., 175, original emphasis.

⁵⁰Ibid. Douglass anticipates this line of argument in his more solidly Garrisonian phase during the 1840s. He affirmed Garrison’s position, for example, by calling slavery and the “traffic in human flesh” a “sin against God” even as he critiqued churches for not doing more to stop it and for accepting religious justifications that perpetuated it, claiming that the “stronghold of Slavery is in the pulpit.” Douglass nonetheless held that if the Gospel, in its proper form, were “preached” and followed, slavery could be eradicated. See Douglass, “American Slavery,” 271. On this score see also Saunders-Hastings, who provides insight into the political possibilities of Douglass’s critiques of the Scottish Free Church’s acceptance of funding from American slaveholders, which has lasting implications for our present moment. See Emma Saunders-Hastings, “Send Back the Bloodstained Money’: Frederick Douglass on Tainted Gifts,” *American Political Science Review* 115 (2021), 729–41.

⁵¹Indeed, such an immanent approach proves especially persuasive within a shared faith tradition, since it presses purportedly religious justifications on the internal moral and theological terms they themselves invoke.

Completing “claims”: the spirit’s power to reshape science and organize coalitions

In 1854, Douglass delivered a landmark speech titled *The Claims of the Negro Ethnologically Considered* at Western Reserve College. This address most clearly illustrates how spiritual discourse could expand the scope of public reason, challenge the authority of racial science, and facilitate the formation of broad moral coalitions across intellectual and denominational divides. By mobilizing prophetic spirituality as a mode of democratic argument, Douglass implicitly challenged Jeffersonian materialist objections to religious discourse, revealing the permeability of the wall between church and state rather than its collapse. Moreover, the claims Douglass advanced in this speech provide a conceptual road map for understanding the connection between spirituality and liberalism at the core of his broader project to reform American democracy by addressing the perversions of religion, science, and history that, through various means, were mobilized to sustain racial subordination.

* * *

Douglass’s *The Claims of the Negro* speech showcased how the work of the spirit (understood as the mobilization of divine power and prophecy) could reconstitute the boundaries of public reason in response to pressing national issues. For Douglass, spiritual discourse supplied a moral counterweight to mid-century racial science and organized collective judgment around a common moral language that transcended purportedly objective empirical claims.⁵² The address begins with an affirmation that “the relation subsisting between the white and black people of this country is the vital question of the age.” Debating the future of slavery and American race relations in the decade leading up to the Civil War thus became “the moral battlefield” upon which intellectuals’ “country and their God now call them.” He suggests that the “country,” a secular political body, and “God,” a spiritual being, both view the standpoint of indifference (what Douglass refers to as “neutrality”) as an unacceptable position in the face of moral crisis. Tacitly invoking the Book of Revelation, he advances that, on the battlefield of ideas, “a man must be hot, or ... cold. The lukewarm and the cowardly will

⁵² I am persuaded by several interpretations of Douglass’s speech, which I hold in productive tension. On the one hand, Jared Hickman argues in his reading of *The Claims of the Negro* that “from Douglass’s standpoint, the American School of Ethnology represented not the advent of a ‘scientific’ racialism—that remains a ways off, in his account—but rather the apotheosis of the longstanding theological debate about race.” Hickman thus shows that “Douglass abandoned the Christian millenarianism of the Garrisonian camp not for a tacitly secularist political abolitionism but rather for what we might call a heretical political-theological abolitionism that provides fruitful fodder for current historical and philosophical debates about secularity, secularism, and immanence.” Douglass’s speech, in short, “hesitates before emergent scientific absolutes and retains a concern for theological questions.” See Hickman, “Douglass Unbound,” 327, 328, 330. For another compelling reading of *The Claims of the Negro* as an expression of Douglass’s religious commitments see Lloyd, “The Affect of God’s Law.” On the interventions that Douglass’s speech makes in nineteenth-century racial science and its broader implications for the history of black scientific thought see Britt Rusert, *Fugitive Science: Empiricism and Freedom in Early African American Culture* (New York, 2017), 124–9. For an extended exegesis see Roderick M. Stewart, “The Claims of Frederick Douglass Philosophically Considered,” in *Frederick Douglass: A Critical Reader*, ed. Bill Lawson and Frank Kirkland (Malden, 1999), 145–72.

be rejected by earnest men on either side of the controversy,” thereby rendering moral indecision itself a culpable stance.⁵³

The first claim Douglass establishes is that black people are part of the human race, which he refers to in his nineteenth-century parlance as “the manhood of the negro,” and, with more patently inclusive language, “the humanity of the negro.”⁵⁴ The truth of this position was frequently contested in antebellum social and political discourse, as evidenced by the persistence of slavery and prejudice, including Jefferson’s widely circulated suspicions about black people’s capacity for rationality.⁵⁵ Even among politicians who opposed slavery, this premise could not be assumed. To address the question of black humanity, Douglass thus draws on spiritual discourse in his account of “what constitutes a man.”⁵⁶

Beyond affirming the humanity of black people through traditional Enlightenment markers, including “reason,” “power to acquire and to retain knowledge,” and “habitudes,” he also includes humans’ “heaven-erected face” and capacity for “prophecies.” Douglass writes that these shared mortal and transcendent capacities separate humans, including black people, from beasts with “a distinction as *eternal* as it is palpable”; that is, a distinction that is as *spiritual* as it is material. He thus pushes against the conceit of racial science, which he calls “scientific moonshine that would connect men with monkeys; that would have the world believe that humanity, instead of resting on its own characteristic pedestal—gloriously independent—is a sort of sliding scale, making one extreme brother to the ourang-ou-tang, and the other to angels, and all the rest intermediates!”⁵⁷

On this account, Douglass asserts that conceptions of the human must recognize humanity’s shared divinity *and* capacity for supernatural prophecy. By contrast, Jefferson’s foreclosure of both spirituality and black rationality leaves him vulnerable—by Douglass’s own lights—to the charge of having imbibed the very “scientific moonshine” he rejects. Douglass then moves to repudiate the contentions of “ethnological scient[ists]” who claim that black and white people do not share a common ancestor, a view that, in effect, “forbid[s] the magnificent reunion of mankind into one brotherhood.”⁵⁸ Strikingly, Douglass maintains that “apart from the authority of the Bible, neither the unity nor diversity of origin of the human family can be demonstrated,” given the limitations of modern science—which, he suggests, proves corruptible when its premises are enlisted to legitimize the denial of black humanity, much as errant interpreters had distorted Christian scripture.

⁵³Frederick Douglass, *The Claims of the Negro, Ethnologically Considered: An Address before the Literary Societies of Western Reserve College, at Commencement, July 12, 1854* (Rochester, 1854), 5. See also Revelation 3:15–16.

⁵⁴On the (secular) import of this claim across Douglass’s writings, especially in his fight with Edward Covey, see, for example, Frank Kirkland, “Enslavement, Moral Suasion, and Struggles for Recognition: Frederick Douglass’s Answer to the Question—‘What Is Enlightenment?’,” in *Frederick Douglass: A Critical Reader*, 243–310; Margaret Kohn, “Frederick Douglass’s Master–Slave Dialectic,” *Journal of Politics* 67 (2005), 497–514; Bromell, *Powers of Dignity*, 92–3.

⁵⁵Douglass, *The Claims of the Negro*, 6, 7; Jefferson, *Notes*, 148.

⁵⁶Douglass, *The Claims of the Negro*, 7.

⁵⁷*Ibid.*, 8, added emphasis.

⁵⁸*Ibid.*, 9, 10.

To elide Douglass's appeal to biblical authority in this critique of scientific discourse is to miss the epistemic work that spirituality performs in his reasoning. For Douglass, spiritual commitment does not displace rational inquiry but supplies the grounds upon which he could arrive at the "truth" of a shared human origin "with almost absolute certainty."⁵⁹ Where Jefferson stopped short of accepting the Gospels' spiritual authority, Douglass affirmed here, as elsewhere, his faith in the Bible as a comprehensive source of theological and moral truth. To be sure, whether theories of human unity should be derived from the Bible, as Douglass held, or apart from it, remains a legitimate question—but it is a question that cannot even be posed if spiritual commitments are foreclosed at the outset.

In positing the Bible as a source of moral authority, Douglass also contends, "For myself I can say, my reason (not less than my feeling, and my faith) welcomes with joy, the declaration of the Inspired Apostle, 'that God has made of one blood all nations of men for to dwell upon all the face of the earth.'" In this view, Enlightenment "reason," Romantic or Transcendentalist "feeling," and religious "faith" operate as overlapping epistemic registers that Douglass apprehends as a unified whole, even as his conviction bears the biblical warrant "that God has made" all people "of one blood."⁶⁰ Rather than eschewing religiously oriented reason, Douglass embraces and extends it by integrating moral and theological premises into the framework of a manifestly scientific account. On this basis, he asserts with confidence that "the whole argument in defence of slavery, becomes utterly worthless the moment the African is proved to be equally a man with the Anglo-Saxon."⁶¹

In confronting how the "Southern pretenders to science" contravened the "Scriptural account of the origin of mankind" and promoted an errant framework of "scientific Christendom," Douglass highlights the possibility that Enlightenment scientific discourse, despite its promises of objectivity and its positivistic orientation toward knowledge production, can fall prey to error, much as "religious" proslavery arguments had done.⁶² Instead of passing over positivistic claims, Douglass confronts them to show how scientific discourse had been co-opted by actors whose aim was not the pursuit of truth but the preservation of a system of slavery from which they materially and politically benefited.⁶³ Thus Douglass mobilizes spiritual authority to expose the epistemic farce of a perspective that presents itself as neutral and empirically grounded, mirroring the strategy he used to refute religious arguments advanced in defense of slavery.

Although *The Claims of the Negro* positions the Bible as providing moral authority in a racialized world, Douglass does not deny the virtues of scientific inquiry. Indeed, Douglass complements his reliance on the moral authority of scripture with

⁵⁹ Ibid., 11.

⁶⁰ Ibid., 12.

⁶¹ Ibid., 14.

⁶² Ibid., 15, 16.

⁶³ Citing prominent authors who have propagated racist theories in the name of science, including Josiah C. Nott, George Gliddon, Samuel George Morton, and Louis Agassiz, Douglass writes, "The lawyers tell us that the credit of a witness is always in order. Ignorance, malice or prejudice, may disqualify a witness, and why not an author?" See Douglass, *The Claims of the Negro*, 16.

empirical “facts” derived from his observations of how “climate and habit” can shape human development, without subordinating empirical inquiry to scripture or scripture to science.⁶⁴ Demonstrating this synthesis, Douglass claims that his reading of the scientific literature and his own observation “have convinced me that from the beginning the Almighty, within certain limits, endowed mankind with organizations capable of countless variations in form, feature and color, without having it necessary to begin a new creation for every new variety.”⁶⁵ He adds complexity to this position by registering his belief that arguments against the “unity of origin of the human race, or species,” are not only “partial” and “superficial,” but “utterly subversive to the happiness of man, and insulting to the wisdom of God.”⁶⁶

Douglass’s sense of morality thus also turns on human “happiness,” a position that echoes Jefferson’s Enlightenment-era articulation in the Declaration of Independence, where the pursuit of happiness appears as one of the “unalienable Rights” endowed by a “Creator” and grounded in “self-evident” truths, including the claim that “all men are created equal.”⁶⁷ Importantly, however, Douglass reworks this reverse echo. He coarticulates “happiness” as a condition of human equality while affirming not a distant Creator or abstract “Nature’s God,” but the active and indwelling “wisdom” of God as a living force in history. In this way, Douglass preserves the moral aspirations of Enlightenment liberalism while insisting that spiritual conviction, rather than mere abstraction, possesses the power to transform human action.

Douglass concludes *The Claims of the Negro* with an appeal to the nation’s intellectual elite, whom he understood as uniquely positioned to shape the future direction of public reason. He warns that the “future public opinion of the land, whether anti-slavery or pro-slavery, whether just or unjust ... must redound to the honor of the Scholars of the country to cover them with shame.” He adds, with uncompromising moral clarity, “There is but one safe road for nations or for individuals. The fate of a wicked man and of a wicked nation is the same. The flaming sword of offended justice falls as certainly upon the nation as upon the man.” Douglass renders these coarticulated claims urgent and palpable as he presses his listeners to acknowledge the rights of black people, whom he presents not only as survivors of oppression but also as bearers of virtue and dignity, wronged simultaneously in the spiritual realm “in the Church,” and in the secular one “in the State.”⁶⁸

Douglass leaves it to his audience to ensure that the “freedom, industry, virtue, and intelligence [of black people] be made a blessing to the country and the world” in order to avoid the possibility that “their multiplied wrongs shall kindle the vengeance of an

⁶⁴Ibid., 31.

⁶⁵Ibid., 32.

⁶⁶Ibid., 34.

⁶⁷Ibid., 34; Thomas Jefferson, “The Declaration of Independence,” in Bernard Bailyn, ed., *The Debate on the Constitution Part 2: Federalist and Anti-Federalist Speeches, Articles, and Letters during the Struggle over Ratification* (New York, 1993), 921–5.

⁶⁸Douglass, *The Claims of the Negro*, 36.

offended God.”⁶⁹ Continuing to affirm the reality of an active and indwelling God who intervenes in human affairs, he insists that “God has no children whose rights may be safely trampled upon. The sparrow may not fall to the ground without the notice of his eye, and men are more than sparrows.”⁷⁰ In this way, Douglass deploys spiritual authority not to displace but to intensify the empirical and philosophical claims he advances throughout his address. To neglect these spiritual commitments—or to blunt their theological resonance—is to overlook the imbrication of faith and reason that Douglass understood as central to his political abolitionism.

In the final lines of *The Claims of the Negro*, Douglass again emphasizes his reverence for spiritual authority alongside his commitment to public reason, telling his learned auditors that he and they had arrived at the college commencement at which he was invited to speak from “vastly different points in the world’s condition.” Though his audience attained their current station of academic achievement through devotion to science, scholarship, and established demonstrations of intellectual mastery in a post-Enlightenment United States, Douglass—a former slave—explains that he arrived there “by little short of a miracle; at any rate, by dint of some application and perseverance.” In this moment, Douglass deliberately refuses to choose between spiritual and secular explanations. Instead, he merges the language of miracle with the ethic of disciplined labor to affirm an understanding of human growth and achievement irreducible to either providence or empiricism alone.⁷¹

Indeed, Douglass believed that humans must be able to think across spiritual and secular registers to grasp the fullest expression of humanity—and the possibilities for liberal democracy—that he sought to articulate. Douglass reprises this conviction, which he mentions at the beginning of his address, by referencing his double status as both “a denizen of the world, and as a citizen of a country rolling in the sin and shame of Slavery, the most flagrant and scandalous that ever saw the sun.” The end of *The Claims of the Negro* fittingly returns to the Bible, a text he had repeatedly mobilized throughout the address as a source of moral and spiritual authority. In doing so, Douglass resists translating its insights into nonreligious idioms, which would obscure what he understood to be the spiritual elements of humanity. Rather than prescribing a social policy or demanding legislative reform, Douglass assumes the posture of a minister, calling his learned audience to elevate their thinking beyond the materialist confines of the world and toward a form of moral reflection grounded in spiritual discernment. He thus concludes with the words of Philippians 4:8: “Whatsoever things are true, whatsoever things are honest, whatsoever things are just, whatsoever things are pure, whatsoever things are lovely, whatsoever things are of good report; if there be any virtue, and if there be any praise, think on these things.”⁷²

⁶⁹Douglass invokes a similar sentiment Jefferson expresses in *Notes on the State of Virginia* (Query XVIII), namely the warning that slavery will initiate divine or cosmic retribution for wrongs committed against black people. See Jefferson, *Notes*, 173.

⁷⁰Douglass, *The Claims of the Negro*, 36. See Matthew 10:29–30.

⁷¹While one might dismiss Douglass’s use of “miracle” here as idiomatic or rhetorical, the sustained and systematic presence of spiritual commitments across his early *oeuvre* points to a sincere belief in the possibility of divine action.

⁷²Douglass, *The Claims of the Negro*, 37.

Valorizing Douglass's commitment to public reason while downplaying his spiritual convictions strips his religious presuppositions of their moral authority. As philosopher Michael Sandel later observed in his critique of John Rawls's *Political Liberalism*, "by advancing religious arguments against so conspicuous an injustice as slavery, the evangelicals who inspired the abolitionist movement were hoping to encourage Americans to view other political questions in moral and religious terms as well."⁷³ Douglass's early belief in the work of the spirit should be read in this light: not as a departure from public reason, but as a means of enlarging it, enabling a more capacious vision of equal rights and dignity within America's liberal democracy. This dynamic, in which spiritual conviction works to expand rather than constrain public reason, sets the stage for Douglass's still bolder engagement with the world-historical, apocalyptic dimensions of the Civil War.

The coming apocalypse: spirituality and the reconfiguration of public reason in Douglass's Civil War speeches

Building on the immanent critiques developed earlier, Douglass's orations during and about the Civil War illustrate the third and final dimension of his spiritual politics: prophecy as a mode of widening and transforming public reason. While assertions of spiritual authority can seem at odds with a liberal democracy, Douglass mobilized eschatological language to generate a sense of urgency during moments of democratic crisis that secular temporality and rationality alone could not fully supply. As political theorist George Shulman has argued, though religious discourse allows for affirmative expressions of "authority," religion is often associated with "dogmatism and depicted as antithetical to democratic life."⁷⁴ Yet Shulman also insists that "registers of speech we find disturbing or potentially antidemocratic can perform truly democratizing and politicizing work." Exemplifying this insight, Douglass frequently invokes the work of the spirit to develop a form of "political counterprophecy" that promises to strengthen "democratic forms of prophetic speech."⁷⁵

Douglass's 1852 "Fourth of July" address, for example, involved more than mere political rhetoric. Instead, Douglass powerfully invokes what might be described as "the authority of a biblical and liberal consensus."⁷⁶ Convictions such as the biblical command to "love thy neighbor" and especially Douglass's more apocalyptic proclamations about God's prosecution of the Civil War could generate a deeper sense of social commitment and solidarity than secular constructions of liberty rooted solely in scientific or procedural grounds—not by abandoning public reason, but by momentarily standing apart from it in order to expose its limits in isolation.⁷⁷ This dynamic

⁷³Michael J. Sandel, "Political Liberalism (Review)," *Harvard Law Review* 107 (1994), 1791–2. On the productive possibilities of biblical authority see also Shulman, "Thinking Authority Democratically."

⁷⁴Shulman, "Thinking Authority Democratically," 727.

⁷⁵Shulman, *American Prophecy*, xv.

⁷⁶*Ibid.*, 19. To be sure, across his early speeches and writings, Douglass consistently asserts moral authority and articulates forms of political organizing and leadership grounded in spiritual conviction.

⁷⁷For examples of Douglass's apocalyptic claims regarding subjects such as British abolition and the Civil War see Frederick Douglass, "The Significance of Emancipation in the West Indies," in *The Portable Frederick*

lends support to theologian Vincent Lloyd's claim that if our understanding of politics involves "not only authority and legitimacy but also ideology critique," then we must also take seriously the affective power of Douglass's spiritual expressions for their potential to reshape private worldviews and motivate collective action in ways that can produce substantive transformations in the political sphere.⁷⁸

Embodying this conception, in the final years leading up to the Civil War, Douglass drew on prophetic language to link emancipation to God's apocalyptic agency, signaling a fundamental alignment between the material and spiritual realms.⁷⁹ In this way, he worked to reconfigure, rather than evacuate, public reason as he mobilized audiences by proclaiming God's capacity to influence human affairs as an active and indwelling presence. In an 1857 speech commemorating the British abolition of slavery throughout its empire, Douglass made this logic explicit. He invoked the work of the spirit by declaring that "there was something Godlike in this decree of the British nation. It was the spirit of the Son of God commanding the devil of slavery to go out of the British West Indies."⁸⁰ Indeed, Douglass's appeal to the Bible as not only a well-spring of moral authority but also, as he understood it, as a source of real *spiritual* power enabled his audiences to envision a form of moral community capable of transcending racial hierarchy and domination at moments when public reason's positivistic resources proved insufficient to secure justice for the oppressed.

Later, near the end of the US Civil War in 1864, Douglass described the "mission" of the conflict in spiritual terms that complemented and intensified what he identified as its moral aim: the abolition of slavery. Douglass argues that despite the wishes of the rebel South and the discrimination black people faced in the North, "events are *mightier* than our rulers, and these Divine forces, with overpowering logic, have fixed upon this war, against the wishes of our Government, the comprehensive character and mission [of abolition] I have ascribed to it."⁸¹ Invoking a more grounded political register, he held that the closer "human governments" came to realizing the "divine" principles of "justice, goodness, [and] conscience," the more "binding and authoritative" they would become.⁸²

For Douglass, then, America's Civil War provided the stage for a direct spiritual intervention into human affairs and the overthrow of governance by slaveholders engaged in "one high-handed act of rebellion against truth, justice, and humanity."⁸³ Such sins could not be cleansed, nor restitution made, by mere moralizing philosophies or legal transformations that had demonstrably failed to abolish the practice and

Douglass, 269–91, at 275; Douglass, "The Decision of the Hour, Substance of a Lecture Delivered at Zion Church," in *The Life and Writings of Frederick Douglass*, vol. 3, *The Civil War*, ed. Philip S. Foner (New York, 1952), 118–25, at 119–20.

⁷⁸Lloyd, "The Affect of God's Law," 308.

⁷⁹For excellent studies related to this point see Blight, *Frederick Douglass' Civil War*; Dilbeck, *Frederick Douglass: America's Prophet*, 93–108.

⁸⁰Douglass, "The Significance of Emancipation in the West Indies," 275.

⁸¹Frederick Douglass, "The Mission of the War," in *The Portable Frederick Douglass*, 326–44, at 340.

⁸²Douglass, "The Decision of the Hour," 122; Frederick Douglass, "What Shall Be Done with the Slaves if Emancipated?," in *The Life and Writings of Frederick Douglass*, 3: 188–225, at 191.

⁸³Douglass, "Decision of the Hour," 122.

effects of the centuries-long enslavement of black people on American soil. Instead, Douglass's eschatological rendering of the Civil War points to powers beyond the struggle against flesh and blood. These powers were capable of enlarging the moral scope of public reason and motivating the kinetic force of Union soldiers who could finally strike a death blow against the spiritual strongholds and principalities sustaining the evils of slavery. Eliding the spiritual stakes of Douglass's political framing of the war obscures his conviction that divine agency could introduce forms of justice capable of transforming a slaveholding society long unresponsive to reasoned argument alone.

Conclusion

What is lost when we foreclose Frederick Douglass's spirituality in our scholarly examinations of his ideas and public commemorations of his life and work? As his writings continue their ascent to canonical status in modern intellectual history and American political theory, we must resist the temptation to translate his faith into secular terms merely to render him more legible within our contemporary frameworks. To do so risks repeating Jefferson's gesture of foreclosure: rendering prophetic voices shaped by spirituality unintelligible and stripping them of their normative and affective force.⁸⁴ Reading Douglass primarily through the lens of secular public reason narrows the full range of possibilities he envisioned for a democratic society. For him, the prophetic coarticulation of faith and reason, which expresses the highest dimensions of one's humanity, can positively transform a liberal order by enabling citizens to recognize—and act on—the work of the spirit. Foreclosing Douglass's commitment to this work limits our historical understanding of the spiritual assumptions and presuppositions that structured early and antebellum American political thought, a tradition Douglass not only inhabited but expanded from within.

Competing interests. The author declares none.

⁸⁴This insight joins a growing body of scholarship that treats religious and prophetic ways of knowing as sites of political reasoning in their own right. In addition to the work of Lloyd, Park, Shulman, and others cited above, see also James Bernard Murphy's recent *The Third Sword: On the Political Role of Prophets* (Cambridge, 2024).

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